

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Law English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

07 Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Jurisdiction - A court's legal authority to hear a matter or exercise power over a party or subject.

Materiality - Importance of information to a legal, regulatory, investor, or business decision.

Allege - State a claim or fact as asserted but not yet proven.

Assert - State a position, claim, right, defense, or privilege.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An email is not the signed agreement

The lesson's internal team has a delivery email but has not reviewed the signed supplier agreement. This is language practice, not legal advice.

01 • Case analyst: The note says the supplier breached the contract, but we have only reviewed the delivery email.

02 • Supervising lawyer: Then that conclusion goes beyond the material currently examined. What can we state accurately?

03 • Case analyst: We can describe what the email says and identify the contract review as pending.

04 • Supervising lawyer: Good. Does the email itself establish the governing jurisdiction or the relevant contractual obligation?

05 • Case analyst: We haven't established either. I shouldn't supply those facts from an assumption.

06 • Supervising lawyer: Nor should we assume materiality before reviewing the obligation and surrounding facts.

07 • Case analyst: Would it be clearer to attribute the allegation rather than assert breach ourselves?

08 • Supervising lawyer: Yes, provided the record identifies who actually made that allegation.

09 • Case analyst: I'll distinguish the recorded communication, any attributed allegation, and the unanswered legal questions.

10 • Supervising lawyer: Then request the signed agreement for review and leave the conclusion open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A witness reports a conversation

Separate fictional training case: a witness reports that a manager promised a refund; no recording or written confirmation is available.

01 • Junior lawyer: The witness says a manager promised a refund. Can we state that the promise occurred?

02 • Senior lawyer: We can state what the witness reported, while keeping corroboration separate.

03 • Junior lawyer: The interview note is detailed, but we have no recording or written confirmation.

04 • Senior lawyer: Detail may help assessment; it doesn't convert a reported account into independently verified fact.

05 • Junior lawyer: Should I say the witness alleges a promise, without asserting its legal effect?

06 • Senior lawyer: Attribute the account clearly. Avoid suggesting a conclusion about enforceability from this information alone.

07 • Junior lawyer: We also haven't identified which jurisdiction's rules would need consideration.

08 • Senior lawyer: Then list that as an open research question, not a fact you can infer.

09 • Junior lawyer: I'll preserve the account and ask what supporting material can appropriately be obtained.

10 • Senior lawyer: Good. Our summary should let the reader distinguish evidence, allegations, and analysis.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A missing attachment and a materiality claim

Separate fictional training case: an internal file lacks a contract attachment, but no one has established whether the signed original included it.

01 • Paralegal: Our file lacks the attachment. The draft summary calls that a material defect in the agreement.

02 • Supervising lawyer: That conflates our incomplete file with the agreement's contents. Have we reviewed the original?

03 • Paralegal: No. We know only that this internal copy doesn't contain the attachment.

04 • Supervising lawyer: Then describe that limitation before making any assertion about the agreement itself.

05 • Paralegal: Would materiality mean whether the missing information matters to the issue being considered?

06 • Supervising lawyer: Broadly, yes, but the relevant assessment depends on facts and the applicable legal context.

07 • Paralegal: So I shouldn't label the omission material merely because the attachment sounds important.

08 • Supervising lawyer: Correct. Request the complete executed version and preserve the source of this copy.

09 • Paralegal: I'll change the summary to an incomplete-file observation, with legal significance unresolved.

10 • Supervising lawyer: That gives us a reliable starting point without disguising uncertainty as a finding.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

Scenario 2 | A draft labeled final

A fictional case folder contains a document named Final Agreement, but its signature fields are blank. No executed version has been located. A colleague wants to call its terms binding.

Role A: You are the case assistant. Explain what the file shows without drawing a legal conclusion.

Role B: You supervise the review. Ask what version evidence is missing and identify the next review step.

Possible opening: The filename says final, but this copy has blank signature fields and no executed version is available.

Success checks

- Separate the filename from execution evidence.
- Avoid deciding enforceability from the supplied facts.
- Agree to seek version evidence and qualified review.

Add a complication: The colleague argues that the filename alone proves acceptance.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A prospective client sends a long description of a dispute and asks for immediate advice. The intake team has not completed its conflict check.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Conflict of interest - A situation where duties to one client, former client, third person, or personal interest may limit representation.

Confidentiality - The professional duty to protect information relating to a client or matter, subject to applicable rules.

Engagement letter - A document defining the representation, scope, fees, responsibilities, and sometimes limitations.

Scope of representation - The agreed boundaries of legal work to be performed.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Clarifying intake before substantive advice

The lesson's prospective client has sent a dispute account; the conflict check is incomplete. No representation is assumed.

01 • Intake coordinator: We've received the dispute description, but the conflict check hasn't been completed.

02 • Prospective client: Can the lawyer tell me what to do immediately while that check is underway?

03 • Intake coordinator: I can't promise substantive advice or representation before the intake review establishes the next step.

04 • Prospective client: What clarification do you need from me now, without another long account?

05 • Intake coordinator: Please confirm the parties' names through the intake channel so the conflict review can proceed.

06 • Prospective client: Does sending information mean we already have an engagement letter or agreed scope?

07 • Intake coordinator: No engagement or scope of representation has been confirmed in this exchange.

08 • Prospective client: I also want to know how the information I've sent will be handled.

09 • Intake coordinator: I'll refer that confidentiality question to the responsible intake professional rather than promise an unsupported rule.

10 • Prospective client: Please confirm the intake status and who will explain the next steps.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Which company is seeking representation?

Separate fictional intake: a director contacts a firm about a dispute involving two related companies; the intended client is unclear.

01 • Intake lawyer: When you say our company, which legal entity is seeking assistance with the dispute?

02 • Company director: There are two related companies involved, and I haven't specified which one would engage you.

03 • Intake lawyer: That distinction matters for the conflict check and any proposed scope of representation.

04 • Company director: Can't you use the group's trading name and sort the entity out later?

05 • Intake lawyer: We should clarify the prospective client before assuming whom the firm would represent.

06 • Company director: I'll confirm the entity names. Does that mean both companies will become clients?

07 • Intake lawyer: No. Supplying names for intake doesn't itself establish an engagement with either company.

08 • Company director: What should I clarify internally before the next conversation with your team?

09 • Intake lawyer: Identify who seeks representation and who can discuss the proposed engagement on its behalf.

10 • Company director: I'll bring that information without describing the firm as already acting for us.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A new issue outside the stated assignment

Separate fictional training case: an existing engagement covers reviewing a lease draft; a client now asks about an unrelated employment dispute.

01 • Client representative: While you review our lease draft, could you advise on an employment dispute too?

02 • Relationship lawyer: Could you clarify whether you are requesting a separate engagement for that matter?

03 • Client representative: I assumed the existing engagement letter covered any legal question from our business.

04 • Relationship lawyer: The stated assignment covers the lease review. We shouldn't assume an unrelated dispute is included.

05 • Client representative: Would the new issue require another conflict-of-interest check before anyone considers advice?

06 • Relationship lawyer: The intake team needs to assess the new matter and determine the appropriate review.

07 • Client representative: Then I should provide limited identifying information through the designated channel first?

08 • Relationship lawyer: Yes. We'll clarify the proposed scope and information handling before treating the new work as accepted.

09 • Client representative: I'll keep the two matters separate when I speak with our team.

10 • Relationship lawyer: Thank you. The lease assignment remains distinct from the employment inquiry under review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

A prospective client sends a long description of a dispute and asks for immediate advice. The intake team has not completed its conflict check.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Before we discuss advice, could you provide the names of the parties and the type of assistance you are seeking? Our team needs to complete intake and confirm the scope of any engagement.

Scenario 2 | A referral without a confirmed client

A fictional consultant introduces a business owner to a firm and asks to join the intake call. The owner has not said whether they want the consultant present, and no engagement is established.

Role A: You coordinate intake. Clarify the owner's preference and the consultant's proposed role before discussing substance.

Role B: You are the business owner. State that the consultant made the introduction but their continuing involvement is undecided.

Possible opening: Before discussing the matter, could we clarify who you want present and in what role?

Success checks

- Separate referral from authorization to participate.
- Keep representation and information-sharing arrangements unconfirmed.
- Agree who will clarify participation before substantive discussion.

Add a complication: The consultant assumes making the referral gives them access to all subsequent discussions.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

A litigation task list has two dates from different documents. The supervising lawyer has not confirmed which deadline controls.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Complaint - A pleading that starts a civil lawsuit by stating claims against the defendant.

Answer - A defendant's pleading responding to the complaint and often asserting defenses.

Motion - A request asking the court to issue an order or take action.

Order - A court's direction or decision on a matter before it.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Compare this wording: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team plans to complete the review.
 - B. The team has completed the review.
 - C. The team is completing the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.
 - B. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - C. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two dates awaiting supervisory review

The lesson's litigation list contains dates from two documents; the supervising lawyer has not confirmed the controlling deadline.

01 • Litigation assistant: I've identified two different dates in the source documents, but neither is confirmed as controlling.

02 • Supervising lawyer: What work have you completed so far on the task list?

03 • Litigation assistant: I've retained both dates with their sources and flagged the conflict for your review.

04 • Supervising lawyer: Good. Don't choose one merely because it appears in the newer-looking document.

05 • Litigation assistant: Should I describe the deadline as confirmed if a date appears in an order?

06 • Supervising lawyer: Not without reviewing the relevant materials and their effect in this matter.

07 • Litigation assistant: Then the source collection is complete, while the deadline determination remains pending.

08 • Supervising lawyer: Correct. Keep the potential scheduling impact visible and route the issue for prompt review.

09 • Litigation assistant: I'll avoid updating dependent tasks as though one date had already been approved.

10 • Supervising lawyer: Bring both documents to me so the next scheduling instruction can be based on review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Drafted is not filed

Separate fictional litigation exercise: an answer has been drafted and awaits lawyer approval; there is no filing confirmation.

01 • Case manager: The dashboard says answer complete. Does that mean it has been filed?

02 • Litigation paralegal: No. The draft is complete, but lawyer approval and filing confirmation are still pending.

03 • Case manager: We should distinguish those stages so the client doesn't assume a procedural step occurred.

04 • Litigation paralegal: Agreed. I'll change the status to draft ready for review, not filed.

05 • Case manager: Have you checked any deadline against the supervising lawyer's instructions for this matter?

06 • Litigation paralegal: That's outside the status shown here. I need to confirm it rather than infer compliance.

07 • Case manager: Please flag that dependency and avoid calling the matter fully on schedule.

08 • Litigation paralegal: I'll bring the draft status and scheduling question to the supervising lawyer together.

09 • Case manager: When filing does occur, what will support the next status update?

10 • Litigation paralegal: The appropriate filing confirmation, reviewed through our case process, rather than the draft's existence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A motion discussed but not authorized

Separate fictional litigation exercise: a team discussed a possible motion, but counsel has not decided whether to pursue it.

01 • Litigation coordinator: The meeting discussed a motion, so I marked motion preparation underway on the tracker.

02 • Associate lawyer: Counsel hasn't decided whether to pursue it. The discussion didn't authorize preparation.

03 • Litigation coordinator: Then my update overstated progress. What status accurately reflects the completed work?

04 • Associate lawyer: The option has been discussed, and the decision on next steps is pending.

05 • Litigation coordinator: Should I assign research or drafting tasks to make progress while we wait?

06 • Associate lawyer: Ask counsel what work is authorized rather than creating tasks from an assumed strategy.

07 • Litigation coordinator: I'll keep that question visible and remove the unsupported underway label.

08 • Associate lawyer: Please retain the discussion note so the unresolved option isn't lost from view.

09 • Litigation coordinator: Understood. The tracker will distinguish an option considered from an approved workstream.

10 • Associate lawyer: That will help counsel give a clear instruction without inheriting a misleading progress claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

A litigation task list has two dates from different documents. The supervising lawyer has not confirmed which deadline controls.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: The task list contains conflicting dates. I have attached both source documents and flagged the issue for your review. Please confirm the controlling deadline before I update the calendar.

Scenario 2 | A hearing request without a confirmed listing

A fictional case record shows that a hearing request was submitted, but no confirmed listing is present. A client asks whether attendance should be arranged for the requested date.

Role A: You are the litigation coordinator. Report the submitted request and pending confirmation separately.

Role B: You are the supervising lawyer. Ask what evidence is available and direct the appropriate status check.

Possible opening: The hearing request was submitted, but the record does not yet confirm a listing.

Success checks

- Distinguish a request from a confirmed listing.
- Avoid inventing an attendance instruction or controlling date.
- Agree a status check with the responsible professional.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to treat the requested date as the confirmed hearing date.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A document reviewer finds an email chain that may contain privileged communications. It is in a review set, not yet a production set.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Discovery - The formal process for obtaining information and evidence from other parties or nonparties.

Deposition - Out-of-court sworn testimony recorded for use in litigation.

Privilege - A legal protection that may permit withholding certain communications or materials.

Work product - Materials prepared in anticipation of litigation that may receive protection from disclosure.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - B. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - C. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - B. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - C. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Requesting review of a potentially privileged chain

The lesson's email chain is in a review set, not a production set, and privilege is unconfirmed.

01 • Document reviewer: Could you review this email chain for potential privilege before any production decision?

02 • Review lawyer: Where is it currently located, and has it been included in a production set?

03 • Document reviewer: It is in the review set only. I haven't determined whether privilege applies.

04 • Review lawyer: Good. Keep that distinction explicit instead of describing it as a disclosure incident.

05 • Document reviewer: I'll provide the review reference and explain which passages prompted the concern.

06 • Review lawyer: Use the restricted review system rather than copying the chain into general messages.

07 • Document reviewer: Should I label it privileged or work product now to resolve the queue?

08 • Review lawyer: Flag it for assessment; those determinations require review in the relevant context.

09 • Document reviewer: Please confirm when you can assess it before the production decision is taken.

10 • Review lawyer: I'll confirm the review slot and record the determination through the discovery workflow.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Requesting a missing attachment for discovery review

Separate fictional discovery exercise: a review email refers to an attachment absent from the collected set; its contents are unknown.

01 • Discovery lawyer: Could you check the collection record for the attachment referenced in this email?

02 • ESI coordinator: Yes. Do you want a collection-status check, or are you assuming it was intentionally withheld?

03 • Discovery lawyer: Only a status check. We don't know why the attachment is absent.

04 • ESI coordinator: I'll trace the item reference without describing the missing contents as established evidence.

05 • Discovery lawyer: Please confirm what can be located before we finish assessing the email's context.

06 • ESI coordinator: If I find a matching file, should it move straight into production?

07 • Discovery lawyer: No. It would need the appropriate review, including any privilege concerns, before that decision.

08 • ESI coordinator: Understood. Locating electronically stored information doesn't itself authorize producing it.

09 • Discovery lawyer: Exactly. Return the collection findings and any unresolved link between the email and attachment.

10 • ESI coordinator: I'll report those limits and request further instructions if the reference cannot be resolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Preparing deposition materials without assuming disclosure

Separate fictional litigation exercise: counsel requests a proposed deposition bundle; some selected documents have unresolved review flags.

01 • Associate lawyer: Could you assemble a proposed deposition bundle and identify documents with unresolved review flags?

02 • Litigation paralegal: Several selections still need review. Should I remove the flags to make the bundle easier to read?

03 • Associate lawyer: No. Counsel needs those flags visible before deciding which materials may be used.

04 • Litigation paralegal: I'll separate cleared selections from items awaiting privilege or work-product assessment.

05 • Associate lawyer: Please don't call the second group privileged as a final determination; assessment is pending.

06 • Litigation paralegal: Understood. What timing should I propose for the review conversation?

07 • Associate lawyer: Ask counsel for a slot before the bundle is finalized, without inventing a deadline.

08 • Litigation paralegal: I'll provide the item references and the specific questions needing a decision.

09 • Associate lawyer: Good. The request is for a reviewable proposal, not authorization to disclose every selection.

10 • Litigation paralegal: I'll confirm that scope when I hand over the bundle for discussion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

A document reviewer finds an email chain that may contain privileged communications. It is in a review set, not yet a production set.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Please review this email chain for potential privilege before a production decision. I've identified the participants and relevant messages. I have not made a final privilege determination.

Scenario 2 | A transcript passage needs a source check

A fictional deposition summary contains a quotation attributed to page twelve, but the available transcript excerpt ends at page ten. No one has checked the complete transcript.

Role A: You are the reviewing lawyer. Request the complete source or a verified passage before relying on the quotation.

Role B: You are the case assistant. Explain the excerpt's limit and arrange the source check without inventing the missing words.

Possible opening: Could you locate the complete transcript so we can verify the quotation attributed to page twelve?

Success checks

- State the page-ten limit accurately.
- Do not treat plausibility as verification.
- Agree a source check before reliance on the quotation.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests retaining the quotation because it sounds consistent with earlier testimony.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A draft memo cites one decision as controlling authority. The case came from another jurisdiction and the research is still preliminary.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Binding authority - Authority a court must follow in the relevant jurisdiction and procedural context.

Persuasive authority - Authority a court may consider but does not have to follow.

Precedent - A prior decision used as legal authority for later cases.

Distinguish - Explain why a case or authority does not control because facts or law differ materially.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Persuasive does not mean controlling

The lesson's preliminary memo cites a decision from another jurisdiction as controlling; its authority has not been established.

01 • Research assistant: The draft calls this decision controlling, although it came from another jurisdiction.

02 • Research lawyer: Then we need to assess its authority rather than assume it binds the relevant court.

03 • Research assistant: Could you explain binding authority and persuasive authority in plain English?

04 • Research lawyer: Binding authority must be followed when applicable; persuasive authority may inform reasoning without controlling it.

05 • Research assistant: So a useful decision isn't automatically a precedent that controls our issue?

06 • Research lawyer: Correct. Jurisdiction, court hierarchy, and the issue need examination before we characterize its role.

07 • Research assistant: The research is still preliminary. I'll preserve that limitation in the discussion.

08 • Research lawyer: Also consider whether relevant facts or reasoning let us distinguish the case.

09 • Research assistant: I'll describe its possible relevance without presenting the memo's legal conclusion as settled.

10 • Research lawyer: Good. Bring the authority question back for review with the supporting research.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A similar outcome with different facts

Separate fictional research exercise: a located decision reaches a favorable outcome, but its facts differ from the client's account.

01 • Junior lawyer: This decision has the outcome we hope for, so I want to lead with it.

02 • Research supervisor: First explain the factual difference. A favorable result alone doesn't establish a close precedent.

03 • Junior lawyer: Would distinguishing the case mean showing why that difference affects its relevance?

04 • Research supervisor: Yes. Explain the meaningful difference rather than merely listing details that don't matter.

05 • Junior lawyer: We haven't assessed whether the difference is legally significant in this matter.

06 • Research supervisor: Then say so. Don't treat a possible distinction as either decisive or irrelevant yet.

07 • Junior lawyer: Should the memo separately discuss the decision's authority and its factual fit?

08 • Research supervisor: Exactly. Those are related questions, but a strong answer to one doesn't resolve the other.

09 • Junior lawyer: I'll bring both questions to review and avoid describing the outcome as guaranteed.

10 • Research supervisor: That will make the research useful without turning analogy into a promise.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A headnote is not the court's full reasoning

Separate fictional research exercise: an assistant has read a case summary but not the full judgment or its subsequent treatment.

01 • Research assistant: The summary states the principle clearly. Can I cite that as the court's complete reasoning?

02 • Research lawyer: Not yet. A summary helps locate an issue, but it doesn't replace reviewing the decision.

03 • Research assistant: So the summary is a research aid, while the judgment supplies the reasoning to examine?

04 • Research lawyer: Correct. We also haven't checked the decision's subsequent treatment or its authority here.

05 • Research assistant: Would calling it binding authority now combine several questions we haven't answered?

06 • Research lawyer: Yes. We need to assess the source, relevant proposition, and applicable authority separately.

07 • Research assistant: I'll locate the judgment and keep the current note labeled preliminary research.

08 • Research lawyer: Please identify the actual passage supporting the proposition rather than copying the summary alone.

09 • Research assistant: Then I'll ask for review of its relevance and any limits before relying on it.

10 • Research lawyer: Good. Clear source distinctions are more useful than an unsupported authoritative label.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

A draft memo cites one decision as controlling authority. The case came from another jurisdiction and the research is still preliminary.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: This decision may help the analysis, but we should not label it binding without checking its authority in the relevant jurisdiction. I'll explain that distinction and identify what further research is needed.

Scenario 2 | Two sources with different purposes

A fictional research file contains a commentary article and a court decision discussing the same issue. Neither source's applicability to the matter has been assessed.

Role A: You supervise research. Explain why commentary and a decision serve different research roles.

Role B: You are the research assistant. Paraphrase the distinction and ask what authority and relevance checks remain.

Possible opening: The article may help explain the issue, but it is not interchangeable with the court's decision.

Success checks

- Distinguish explanation from judicial authority.
- Keep applicability unresolved for both sources.
- Agree to examine the decision and its authority before characterizing it.

Add a complication: The article is easier to read, and a colleague proposes citing it as controlling authority.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A draft services agreement requires delivery within ten days. The commercial team needs fifteen days and wants the contract team to propose wording.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Representation - A statement of fact made by a party, often used to allocate risk.

Warranty - A promise or assurance about a fact, condition, product, service, or performance.

Indemnity - A clause requiring one party to cover certain losses, claims, or liabilities.

Limitation of liability - A clause limiting the amount or type of damages recoverable.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
 - B. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.
 - B. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - C. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Proposing fifteen days without announcing agreement

The lesson's services draft says ten days; the commercial team needs fifteen. Wording remains subject to legal and counterparty review.

01 • Commercial manager: The draft requires delivery within ten days, but our team needs fifteen.

02 • Contract lawyer: We can propose a redline, provided it is clear that the change requires review and agreement.

03 • Commercial manager: Could you tell the customer that fifteen days is now the contractual commitment?

04 • Contract lawyer: Not before agreement. Our proposal doesn't amend the draft merely because we prefer it.

05 • Commercial manager: Should we also check whether delivery wording affects any related warranty provision?

06 • Contract lawyer: Yes. Connected terms need review rather than an isolated number change.

07 • Commercial manager: I can explain the operational requirement, but I can't approve the legal wording.

08 • Contract lawyer: Then bring that requirement into the negotiation and leave the drafting decision with the review team.

09 • Commercial manager: I'll present fifteen days as our requested timing, not as an accepted term.

10 • Contract lawyer: For review, I propose replacing 'within ten days' with 'within fifteen days', leaving the existing timing trigger and other wording unchanged. This remains subject to legal review and counterparty agreement.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Scope reduction instead of an unsupported warranty

Separate fictional contract negotiation: a customer requests support for all equipment, while the supplier's proposal covers one named product line.

01 • Customer procurement lead: Could the warranty cover all our equipment, not only the named product line?

02 • Supplier contract manager: That's broader than the proposal. We can assess it, but cannot confirm coverage today.

03 • Customer procurement lead: Would keeping the current price be possible if we narrowed the request?

04 • Supplier contract manager: We can take a defined scope for review; pricing and warranty wording remain unapproved.

05 • Customer procurement lead: Then let's compare the named product line with a separately assessed expansion.

06 • Supplier contract manager: Agreed. We should also check related representations rather than promise capabilities we haven't verified.

07 • Customer procurement lead: I can identify the equipment list, but I won't describe expanded coverage as agreed.

08 • Supplier contract manager: Please do. That will make the review concrete without changing the current proposal silently.

09 • Customer procurement lead: We'll return to price after the scope and proposed terms have been assessed.

10 • Supplier contract manager: Good. For now, both the expansion and its conditions remain open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A liability request needs coordinated review

Separate fictional contract exercise: procurement requests a broader indemnity while the draft's limitation-of-liability section is still under review.

01 • Procurement manager: Can we accept the broader indemnity today and discuss the liability limit later?

02 • Contract counsel: Those provisions may interact. We should review them together before confirming acceptance.

03 • Procurement manager: I'm trying to keep negotiations moving. What can I offer as a practical next step?

04 • Contract counsel: Offer a coordinated review of the requested indemnity and the limitation-of-liability wording.

05 • Procurement manager: Could I say the business accepts the concept, subject to wording?

06 • Contract counsel: Only if that accurately reflects authorized instructions. We haven't established such acceptance here.

07 • Procurement manager: Then I'll say we are evaluating the request and ask for the counterparty's priority.

08 • Contract counsel: That preserves room for negotiation without inventing approval or explaining a legal effect prematurely.

09 • Procurement manager: I'll bring their response and the linked clauses to the review discussion.

10 • Contract counsel: Good. We can then formulate a conditional proposal grounded in the actual instructions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

A draft services agreement requires delivery within ten days. The commercial team needs fifteen days and wants the contract team to propose wording.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: Our delivery team can commit to fifteen days under the current scope. Could we revise the proposed period accordingly? I'll send the business rationale for legal review with the redline.

Scenario 2 | A milestone definition is missing

A fictional draft ties payment to completion of training, but the parties have not agreed whether completion means delivering the session or participants passing an assessment. No payment change is approved.

Role A: You represent the supplier's commercial team. Clarify the two meanings and propose a reviewable definition.

Role B: You coordinate contract review for the customer. State which interpretation needs internal confirmation.

Possible opening: Before we negotiate the payment milestone, could we clarify what completion of training means here?

Success checks

- Name both interpretations.
- Keep the payment obligation and definition unagreed.
- Agree an internal review step before making a conditional proposal.

Add a complication: A participant asks you to promise payment on delivery while the definition is still unresolved.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An employee interview contains a report of possible misconduct. A manager asks to describe the allegation as a confirmed violation in a summary.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Due diligence - Structured review of facts, documents, obligations, and risks before a transaction or decision.

Disclosure - Providing required or relevant information to a party, regulator, investor, court, or public filing.

Enforcement action - A regulator's action to investigate, stop, penalize, or remedy alleged violations.

Remediation - Corrective action taken to fix a problem and prevent recurrence.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An interview allegation is not a confirmed violation

The lesson's interview reports possible misconduct; a manager wants the summary to call it a confirmed violation.

01 • Investigation analyst: The interview contains a report of possible misconduct, not a confirmed violation.

02 • Compliance manager: Can we use stronger wording so leadership understands the seriousness of the issue?

03 • Investigation analyst: We can take the report seriously without claiming a finding the evidence doesn't establish.

04 • Compliance manager: Then how should we distinguish the allegation from our current assessment?

05 • Investigation analyst: Attribute the account and state that corroboration and the relevant review remain pending.

06 • Compliance manager: Would proposing remediation mean we have already concluded a violation occurred?

07 • Investigation analyst: We should explain any proposed action's purpose separately, rather than let it imply a finding.

08 • Compliance manager: I'll avoid presenting the summary as an enforcement action or final determination.

09 • Investigation analyst: Please preserve the unresolved questions and route the information through the appropriate restricted process.

10 • Compliance manager: Agreed. The summary will reflect the report's seriousness and its actual evidential status.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A due-diligence gap is not a clean result

Separate fictional transaction review: due diligence received no response to one questionnaire section; no independent check has resolved it.

01 • Transaction manager: The questionnaire has no issues listed in that section. Can we call the review clean?

02 • Due-diligence lawyer: The section is unanswered, not a confirmed negative response. That distinction needs to remain visible.

03 • Transaction manager: So silence doesn't establish that no relevant matter exists for disclosure?

04 • Due-diligence lawyer: Correct. We have an information gap and no independent check resolving it.

05 • Transaction manager: Could the executive summary say the company withheld something important?

06 • Due-diligence lawyer: We don't know why the response is missing. Don't turn an omission into an allegation of intent.

07 • Transaction manager: I'll describe the unanswered section and request clarification through the review team.

08 • Due-diligence lawyer: Also identify what decision depends on the missing information without predicting the answer.

09 • Transaction manager: Then we can discuss the gap's implications after the response is assessed.

10 • Due-diligence lawyer: Exactly. The due-diligence status is incomplete, neither clean nor a confirmed adverse finding.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A remediation step without a causal conclusion

Separate fictional compliance exercise: a team added a second review to an expense process after an allegation; the investigation is unfinished.

01 • Operations manager: We added a second review, so can the summary say the alleged problem has been proven and fixed?

02 • Compliance reviewer: No. The process change is confirmed, but the investigation remains unfinished.

03 • Operations manager: I thought remediation meant we had already established exactly what went wrong.

04 • Compliance reviewer: Here, describe the precautionary process change and its purpose without implying a final finding.

05 • Operations manager: We also haven't tested whether the extra review addresses the concern effectively.

06 • Compliance reviewer: Then effectiveness is another open question, separate from whether the step was introduced.

07 • Operations manager: I'll state that the review was added while the allegation is still being assessed.

08 • Compliance reviewer: Good. Avoid claiming either confirmed misconduct or completed remediation on this evidence.

09 • Operations manager: We'll bring the investigation status and the process-check results to the next review.

10 • Compliance reviewer: That will distinguish the action taken from conclusions that still require support.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

An employee interview contains a report of possible misconduct. A manager asks to describe the allegation as a confirmed violation in a summary.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: At this stage, we have an allegation and an interview record. The finding is not established. I'll use neutral wording and identify the questions that the investigation still needs to resolve.

Scenario 2 | An inquiry mistaken for enforcement

A fictional organization receives a request for information from a regulator. The supplied record contains no finding, sanction, or enforcement decision. A manager calls it a penalty notice.

Role A: You prepare compliance updates. Describe the received request and correct the unsupported label.

Role B: You are the manager. Ask which facts can be stated and who should assess the response.

Possible opening: The document requests information; the record does not show a penalty or enforcement finding.

Success checks

- Describe the document without either exaggerating or dismissing it.
- Keep its legal significance subject to qualified review.
- Agree the response-review owner rather than inventing a deadline or obligation.

Add a complication: Another colleague wants to call the request routine and harmless, which is also unassessed.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

Two team members disagree about settlement priorities. One prioritizes timing; the other prioritizes confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Settle - Resolve a dispute by agreement rather than final adjudication.

Reserve rights - State that a party is not waiving rights or remedies by acting now.

Stipulate - Agree formally to a fact, issue, procedure, or condition.

Object - State a legal objection to a question, evidence, request, or procedure.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - B. We can record their agreement without asking them.
 - C. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - B. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.
 - C. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Timing and confidentiality before client instructions

The lesson's team disagrees on settlement priorities: one values timing, the other confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.

01 • Lead counsel: Let's hear both priorities before preparing the client discussion. What does each concern address?

02 • Associate counsel: One team member prioritizes timing, while the other wants confidentiality considered explicitly.

03 • Lead counsel: Have we established the client's own priorities, or only the team's preferences?

04 • Associate counsel: Only the team's preferences. We shouldn't describe either as the client's instruction to settle.

05 • Lead counsel: Agreed. Prepare questions that let the client explain the tradeoff rather than assume agreement.

06 • Associate counsel: Should we also distinguish discussing possible terms from authority to accept a settlement?

07 • Lead counsel: Yes. Decision authority must be clarified before anyone communicates acceptance on the client's behalf.

08 • Associate counsel: I'll present both priorities neutrally and identify what remains unresolved.

09 • Lead counsel: Invite any other relevant concern, then summarize the instructions accurately after the discussion.

10 • Associate counsel: Understood. Today's preparation produces questions, not a settlement decision or a promise of terms.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Agreeing a chronology without conceding liability

Separate fictional case conference: counsel considers asking the client about agreeing a limited chronology; no stipulation has been authorized.

01 • Case conference chair: We should clarify the proposed scope before asking whether the client would stipulate to anything.

02 • Associate lawyer: The discussion concerns a limited chronology, not an agreement about liability.

03 • Case conference chair: Has the client authorized even that limited proposal, or is this still preparation?

04 • Associate lawyer: It is still preparation. We need instructions and review of the exact points.

05 • Case conference chair: Then invite the factual reviewer's concerns before presenting the option to the client.

06 • Associate lawyer: I'll ask which dates are supported and which remain disputed in the record.

07 • Case conference chair: Good. Don't assume a possible stipulation resolves every issue connected to those dates.

08 • Associate lawyer: And any proposal to reserve rights needs qualified review, not a casual phrase added for reassurance.

09 • Case conference chair: Exactly. Close the meeting with the open factual points and the person seeking instructions.

10 • Associate lawyer: I'll seek the instructions after review and record that no agreement was reached today.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Protecting a dissenting settlement concern

Separate fictional mediation preparation: the commercial lead favors speed, but the operations representative has not discussed implementation feasibility.

01 • Mediation counsel: Before we recommend a settlement approach, we haven't heard operations on implementation feasibility.

02 • Operations representative: Thank you. I can't confirm feasibility until the proposed obligations are defined more clearly.

03 • Mediation counsel: Are you objecting to settlement itself, or to treating implementation as already confirmed?

04 • Operations representative: The latter. I don't want our silence represented as an operational commitment.

05 • Mediation counsel: I'll make that distinction. The commercial preference for speed doesn't answer your scope question.

06 • Operations representative: Who will decide which conditions can be offered once we understand the work?

07 • Mediation counsel: We need the appropriate client instructions; this preparation meeting doesn't supply that authority.

08 • Operations representative: Then I can help identify the operational questions without approving the proposed terms.

09 • Mediation counsel: Exactly. We'll take those questions to the decision discussion and keep them visible.

10 • Operations representative: Please close with implementation unresolved, not with an assumed agreement to proceed immediately.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Two team members disagree about settlement priorities. One prioritizes timing; the other prioritizes confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Let's separate the objectives before discussing terms. How important are timing and confidentiality to the client? We can present the options and their implications for the client's instructions.

Scenario 2 | An enthusiastic response is not acceptance

In fictional settlement preparation, a business representative says an option sounds promising. They have not authorized acceptance, and counsel has not reviewed the proposed wording. Another participant wants to announce a deal.

Role A: You facilitate the discussion. Clarify the difference between interest and instructions to accept.

Role B: You are the business representative. Explain that you want further review and identify the decision still needed.

Possible opening: Promising describes your reaction, but could we clarify whether any acceptance has actually been authorized?

Success checks

- Preserve the absence of acceptance authority.
- Invite the representative's actual instruction.
- Close with review and decision responsibilities clear, not a claimed deal.

Add a complication: A participant says a quick announcement would create useful momentum.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Before we discuss advice, could you provide the names of the parties and the type of assistance you are seeking? Our team needs to complete intake and confirm the scope of any engagement.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: B - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

B: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

C: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

Check 2: A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

B: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

C: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

Model response: The task list contains conflicting dates. I have attached both source documents and flagged the issue for your review. Please confirm the controlling deadline before I update the calendar.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: A - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

B: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

C: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

Check 2: C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

B: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

C: The requested action and information are explicit.

Model response: Please review this email chain for potential privilege before a production decision. I've identified the participants and relevant messages. I have not made a final privilege determination.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: This decision may help the analysis, but we should not label it binding without checking its authority in the relevant jurisdiction. I'll explain that distinction and identify what further research is needed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

B: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

C: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

Check 2: A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

B: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

C: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

Model response: Our delivery team can commit to fifteen days under the current scope. Could we revise the proposed period accordingly? I'll send the business rationale for legal review with the redline.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: At this stage, we have an allegation and an interview record. The finding is not established. I'll use neutral wording and identify the questions that the investigation still needs to resolve.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: Silence does not establish agreement.

B: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

C: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

Check 2: B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

B: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

C: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

Model response: Let's separate the objectives before discussing terms. How important are timing and confidentiality to the client? We can present the options and their implications for the client's instructions.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Law English

Professional audience: lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Original fictional case: An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: Jurisdiction: A court's legal authority to hear a matter or exercise power over a party or subject. / Materiality: Importance of information to a legal, regulatory, investor, or business decision. / Allege: State a claim or fact as asserted but not yet proven. / Assert: State a position, claim, right, defense, or privilege.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level